

Blues and jazz

Jazz emerged from the USA around 1900, and it has its origins in blues and gospel music. Mostly improvised, it features distinctive syncopations (shifted accents), “swung” rhythms, and virtuosic solos.

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Jazz chords

Most jazz chords are triads comprising the root (tonic), 3rd, and 5th, with an added 7th. The 3rd and 7th intervals may be flattened (“bent”) to create a distinctively spicy sound. Occasionally some chords may be omitted. Jazz music is rarely notated in full. Instead, chord symbols are used to indicate which notes should be played, and the player improvises.

Standard jazz chord
One of the most useful jazz harmonies is a minor chord (which has a flattened 3rd) with an extra flattened 7th.

Flattened 7th

Flattened 3rd

Cmi⁷

Compound chord
Chords containing intervals greater than an octave are called compound chords.

Added 11th

Added 9th

Cmi¹¹

Chromatic chord
Chromatic notes outside the basic triad, which are added for further color, are known as chromatic chords.

Flattened 9th

Flattened 5th

C^{7(b9)}

Chord voicing
The notes of a chord can be arranged or “voiced” in different ways above the root.

6th

3rd

5th

Root

C⁶

12-bar blues

One of the most important chord progressions in jazz is the 12-bar (or 12-measure) blues. It is a pattern based on just three chords arranged in a particular sequence: I (tonic), IV (sub-dominant), and V (dominant). Arranged normally in three four-bar (or four-measure) phrases, it is the harmonic basis for many blues songs.

▷ Progression in the key of C major

With chord I predominating, chord IV appears in three bars (measures). Chord V appears only in bar (measure) nine.

Bar 1 C I	Bar 2 C I	Bar 3 C I	Bar 4 C I
Bar 5 F IV	Bar 6 F IV	Bar 7 C I	Bar 8 C I
Bar 9 G V	Bar 10 F IV	Bar 11 C I	Bar 12 C I